hand off one of Pottinger's servants and attempted to have the envoy himself assassinated. The Wazir had then opened secret negotiations with Mohammad Shah of Persia whose armies had until recently been encamped before his city, declaring, 'I swear to God that I prefer the fury of the King of Kings [the Shah] to the kindliness of a million of the English.'[76]

Macnaghten was uncertain if the fault for the breakdown in relations lay with Yar Mohammad or with the inexperienced Pottinger, so he decided to despatch an embassy to try to win back Herat. Macnaghten asked Burnes to lead this mission, but the latter shrewdly declined, wanting to be around in Kabul ready to step in and replace Macnaghten when the latter returned and suspecting – rightly as it turned out – that the mission to Herat was unlikely to succeed. So Macnaghten sent in his place the Persian-speaking D'Arcy Todd, a former colleague of Henry Rawlinson in the British military mission to Teheran. 'Young Pottinger allowed himself to be apologised to for their threatening to murder him,' wrote Burnes to a friend. 'Major Todd starts tomorrow for Herat, and I predict can do nothing, for nothing is to be done with them.'[77]

Todd's orders were simple: to befriend Yar Mohammad and turn Herat into a pro-British ally on the Persian border, and to settle the frontier with Shah Shuja's dominions. But instead, before long, Todd was writing back in horror at the 'arbitrary and oppressive exactions' being committed by Yar Mohammad, Britain's nominal ally, in his efforts to restore the Herat treasury:

> The person selected was generally a Khan who had enjoyed favour and was therefore supposed to possess wealth, or an executioner convicted of amassing wealth in the non-performance of his duties. The culprit was then put to the torture, the commonest method being by boiling or roasting or baking over a slow fire. The horrible ingenuities practised on these occasions are too disgusting to be more than alluded to. The wretch, writhing in agony, gradually disgorged his wealth and learned before he died that his wives and daughters had been sold to the Turkomans, or divided amongst the sweepers and servants of his murderers. Of two recent victims one was half-roasted and then cut into very small pieces, the other parboiled and afterwards baked.[78]

Herat presented the British with a dilemma they would become increasingly familiar with during the occupation – and one that later colonisers of the region would also have to face: should you try to 'promote the interests of humanity', as Todd put it in one letter to Macnaghten, and champion social reform, banning traditions such as the stoning to death of adulterous women? Wade at the Intelligence Department was, for one, clear where he